Han's Crime

By Shiga Naoya

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR 1: *In an unusual incident, a young Chinese juggler called Han severed his wife's carotid artery during a performance with a knife the size of a carver. The young wife died on the spot. Han was immediately arrested.*

ACTOR 2: *The act was witnessed by an audience of over three hundred. But it was not at all known whether this incident, which had occurred before so many eyes, was a deliberate act or an accident.*

ACTOR 1: *For this performance, Had made his wife stand in front of a thick board. From a distance of twelve feet, he hurled several of the carver-sized knives to form an outline of her body not two inches removed from it.*

ACTOR 2: *The judge commenced by interrogating the Stagehand of the troupe.*

TOGETHER: *Hans' Crime by Shinga Naoya*

JUDGE: What is Han's ordinary behavior like?

STAGEHAND: He's a good person. He doesn't gamble, fool around with other women, or drink. About a year ago, he converted to Christianity. His English is good, and when he has the time he often reads collections of sermons.

JUDGE: And his wife?

STAGEHAND: She was a good person too. As you know, people o four sort aren't' always known for their strict morals. One often hears of somebody running off with somebody else's wife. Han's wife was a beautiful woman, although on the small side, and she now and then got

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solicitations of that sort. But she never took up with such people.

JUDGE: What were their dispositions like?

STAGEHAND: Toward others, they were both extremely kind and gentle. They never thought of themselves and never got angry. And yet . . . I'm afraid this may be to Han's detriment, but to tell the truth, when it came to their own relationship, they were surprisingly cruel to each other.

JUDGE: Had they always been that way?

STAGEHAND: No. About two years ago, the wife gave birth. The baby was premature, and died in three days or so. But after that, it was clear even to us that their relationship was slowly going to the bad. They would often have arguments over the most trivial things. At such times, Hand would suddenly turn dead pale. But in the end, no matter what, he always fell silent. When you looked at this face, there was a terrible, uncontrollable anger in it. Once I suggested that if things were so bad between them it might be good to get a divorce. He said that there was no way he could love his wife. It was only natural, he said, if a woman he did not love gradually came not to love him. It was why he took to reading the Bible and collections of sermons.

JUDGE: What is your opinion of the incident? Was it deliberate or an accident?

STAGEHAND: He gave a short cry: 'Aa!' That was what drew my attention to what had happened. The blood suddenly gushed out of the wife's neck. Even so, she remained upright for a moment. Her body was held in place by the knife's sticking in the board behind her. Then, all of a sudden, her knees buckled, the knife came out and collapsing all together she fell forward. There was nothing anyone could do. We all of us just went stiff and watched. But it seems to me that for those few seconds he

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was just like us. It was only afterward that I thought: He's murdered her at last. Han wend dead pale and stood there with his eyes closed. We drew the curtain down and tried to revive the woman, but she was already dead. Han blurted out: 'How could I make such a blunder?' Then he knelt, in a long silent prayer.

NARRATOR: Dismissing the Chinese stagehand, the judge finally had Han himself brought in.

JUDGE: I've been questioning the owner-manager and the stagehand. I will now ask you some questions. . . Have you never loved your wife at all?

HAN: From the day I married her until the day she had the baby, I loved my wife with all my heart.

JUDGE: Why did the birth become a source of discord?

HAN: Because I knew it wasn't my child.

JUDGE: Do you know who the father was?

HAN: I have an idea it was my wife's cousin. He was a close friend of mine. It was he who suggested that we get married. He introduced me to her.

JUDGE: Was there a relationship before she married you?

HAN: Of course there was. The baby was born the eighth month after the marriage.

JUDGE: The baby died shortly afterwards? What was the cause of death?

HAN: Yes. It choked at the breast.

JUDGE: Was that a deliberate act of your wife's?

HAN: She said it was an accident.

JUDGE: Did your wife tell you about the relationship?

HAN: No, she didn't. Nor did I ask her about it. I felt that the baby's death was a judgment on her for what he'd done. I thought that I myself should be as forgiving as possible.

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JUDGE: But, in the end, you couldn't forgive her?

HAN: That's right. My feeling remained that the baby's death wasn't enough of a judgment.

JUDGE: You didn't think of divorcing her?

HAN: I often thought I'd like a divorce. But I never said anything. I was weak. And my wife had said that if I divorced her she would not survive.

JUDGE: Did your wife love you?

HAN: She did not love me.

JUDGE: If that was so, why did she say such a thing?

HAN: I think it was from the necessity of going on living. Her brother had broken up the household back home, and she knew that no respectable man would marry a woman who'd been the wife of a road-player.

JUDGE: Did your wife feel any sympathy for you?

HAN: I can't think she felt any sympathy. I believe that for my wife, living with me was an extraordinary hardship. My wife simply observed, with cruel eyes, the gradual destruction of my life.

JUDGE: Did you ever think of killing your wife? (SILENCE) Han, did you ever think of killing your wife?

HAN: (PAUSE) I'd often thought, before then, that it would be good if she were dead.

JUDGE: Then, if the law had allowed it, you might have killed her?

HAN: I was afraid of the law, and I had never had such thoughts before. It was merely because I was weak. But even though I was weak, my desire to live my own life was strong.

JUDGE: So, after that, you thought about killing your wife?

HAN: I didn't make my mind up to it. But I did think about it.

JUDGE: How long before the incident was this?

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HAN: The night before. Toward daybreak.

JUDGE: Had you quarreled that evening?

HAN: Yes . . about something so trivial it isn't worth mentioning.

JUDGE: Tell me anyway.

HAN: It was about food. When I'm hungry, I get irritable. The way she dawdles over the preparations for supper made me angry. I went to bed, but I couldn't sleep at all. I looked to one side and the other, always hesitating, without the courage to want what I wanted, without the courage to get rid of what was unbearable. It was all due to my relationship with my wife. I could see no light in my future. What with the pain and unhappiness of it all, I was being poisoned. When the poisoning was complete, I would die. Although alive, I would be a dead man. And though this was what I had come to, I was still trying to put up with it. It would be good if she died – one part of me kept having that dirty, hateful thought. If this was how things were, why didn't I kill her. The consequences of such an act did not trouble me now. I might be put in jail. Who could tell how much better life in jail might be than this life. At last, I grew tired. My thoughts began to blur. As my tensed up feelings relaxed, my dark thoughts of murder faded away. A feeling of loneliness came over me. I even felt pity for my own weak spirit . . . and then, at last, the night was over. It seemed to me that my wife hadn't slept either.

JUDGE: Why didn't you think of leaving your wife?

HAN: For me there was a great difference. (Pause – Judge nods) But, between my thinking about such a thing and actually deciding to kill here, there was still a wide gap. That day, from early morning on, I felt insanely keyed up. But I no longer thought of killing her, as I had the night

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before. And I was not at all worried about that day's performance. If I had been, I would not have chosen that particular act. We had many other acts. Finally, that evening, our turn came. As usual, I demonstrated to the audience that the knives were sharp by slicing though a piece of paper and sticking a knife into the stage. My wife, wearing a gaudy Chinese costume, came on. She stepped up to the thick board and stood bolt upright with her back to it. For the first time since the night before, we exchanged looks. Only then did I realize the danger of having chosen this act for tonight. I began to feel that I could not trust my own arm. Closing my eyes, I attempted to calm myself. My body started to sway. I drove in the first knife above her head. Each time one hit, I thought: Thank God. Calm down, calm down, I thought. I drove in a knife to the left of her throat. I was about to drive in the next one to the right, when suddenly a strange look came over her face. She must have felt an impulse of violent fear. Dizziness struck me. But even so, with all my strength, almost without a target, as though aiming in the dark, I threw the knife . . . (LONG PAUSE) I've killed her at last, I thought.

JUDGE: How do you mean? That you'd done it on purpose?

HAN: Yes. I suddenly felt as if I had

JUDGE: Afterwards, you knelt by the body in silent prayer . . . ?

HAN: That was a trick that occurred to me at the moment. I knew everyone thought I seriously believed in Christianity. While pretending to pray, I was thinking about what attitude I should take.

JUDGE: You felt sure that what you'd done was intentional?

HAN: Yes. And I thought right away I could make out it was an accident.

JUDGE: But why did you think it was deliberate murder?

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HAN: Because of my feelings, which were unhinged.

JUDGE: So you thought you'd skillfully deceived the other?

HAN: I acted surprised in a natural manner, was considerably agitated, and also displayed grief. But any perceptive person, I believe, could have seen that I was playacting. That night, I decided that I would have to be found innocent. Everyone knew we'd been on bad terms, of course, so there was bound to be a suspicion of murder. I couldn't do anything about that. But if I insisted, throughout, that it was an accident, that would be the end of it. There was no proof. In the end, I though, I would be acquitted for lack of evidence. Soon, thought, for some reason, a doubt rose up in me as to whether I myself believed it was murder. The night before, I had thought about killing her . . . but was that alone a reason for deciding it was murder? Gradually, I became unsure. I was so happy. I wanted to shout for joy.

JUDGE: Was it because you yourself could now believe that it was an accident?

HAN: No. I'm still unsure of that. It was because it was completely unclear, even to myself, which it has been. It was because I could now tell the truth and be found innocent. Being found innocent meant everything to me now. For that purpose, it was far better to be able to be honest, even if it meant saying I didn't know which it was. Come what may it was no longer a question of a confession of guilt.

JUDGE: (Pause) On the whole, it seems to be the truth . . . Do you not feel the slightest sorrow about your wife's death?

HAN: None whatsoever. And up to now, no matter what my feeling of hatred for her, I never imagined that I'd be able to talk so cheerfully about her death.

JUDGE: That will be all. You may step down.

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NARRATOR: Han, after a slight wordless bow, left the room. The judge felt an excitement, he could not put a name to it, surge up in him. Quickly, he took kup his pen. And, then and there, he wrote: "Innocent."

SOURCE INFORMATION

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